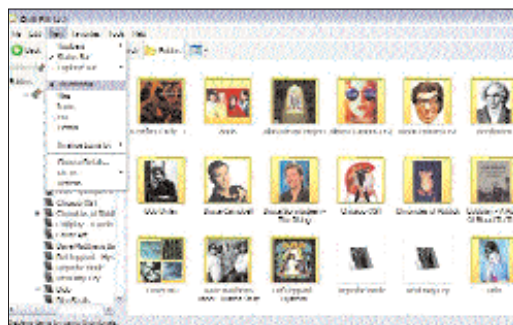


representative photo. Such visual representations make your music collection far easier to browse through.

While thumbnails are nice for folders containing pictures, XP has an option for your doc-



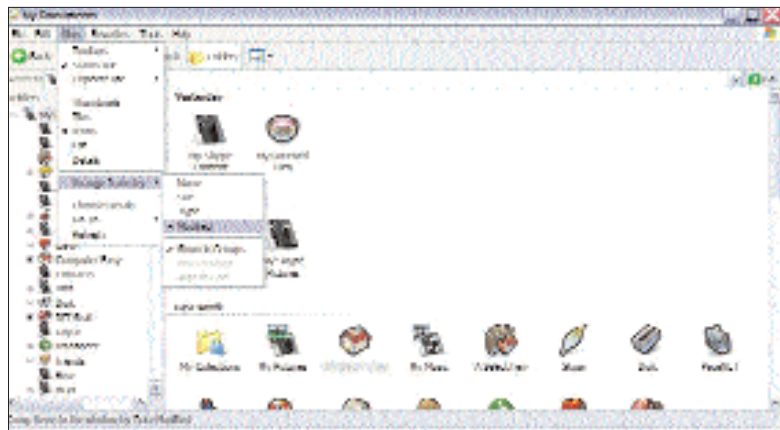
Your music collection will look all the better for Thumbnails, plus it becomes easier to access

uments as well. Windows XP can arrange a folder's contents into groups. Each group is based upon file type, such that you have all your folders together; similarly for your PDF files, your DOC files, your XLS files, and so on. To access this view click on View > Arrange Icons by, and then click on Show in Groups.

While arranging files based on their extensions is useful if you wish to locate an Excel file from within your document folder, you can also use this view to cluster files together based on date. Under the "Arrange Icons by" sub-menu, choose the Modified field to do so. Windows XP will now arrange your folder content according to when you last created or modified it. It arranges content in user-friendly language such as Today, Yesterday, Earlier this week, Last week and so on, stretching to Two years ago. This view thus offers a data timeline of sorts.

Cataloguing Your Data

Creating partitions, slotting data, and changing default views go a long way to allow access to your data in a more methodical manner. However there are times when you need to rely on software to do the dirty work for you. The most useful of these are programs that create a library of your content—for you to search and access from. Such a library can be



Arranging icons in groups, and then by date modified allows for a timeline-like view of your data

Recommended

Jack of all: J River's Media Center is a comprehensive catalogue and search tool for a range of media—audio, video, images and podcasts. It also supports advanced features such as CD ripping, audio conversion, automatic online lookup for metadata and album art, music and video syncing to portable media players (including the iPod), a 10-foot interface, and also supports audio and video streaming to supported portables, media players and other computers.

built on top of almost any content type. We will make brief recommendations on the software to use to categorise each media type on your hard drive.

Your Music Data

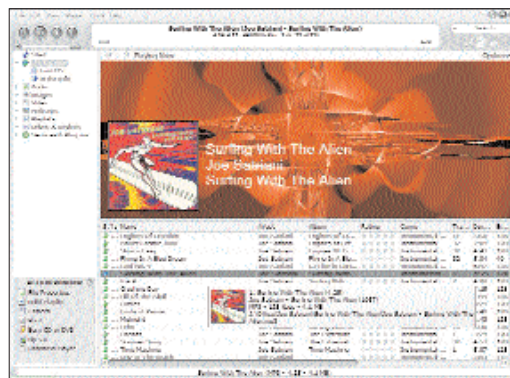
Any music software worth its weight in MB creates, and searches within, a library of your music. This is done across all your folders, partitions, and hard drives. Software such as this will also allow you to search your music library based on ID3 tags and will even let you back up the library. You can choose between Windows Media Player 10, Winamp 5.x, RealPlayer 10.x, iTunes 6.x, and so on. For a player that can handle most of the media out there, apart from offering decent library functionality, we recommend RealPlayer. Apple iPod users should, of course, stick to iTunes for best results.

Your Video Data

A good music manager will also catalogue your video clips and movies. Once again, you can choose from Winamp, Windows Media Player and RealPlayer, but we recommend RealPlayer for its wide range of media support.

Your Photos And Pictures

The software to go for here is Google Picasa. It organises your photo content and then lets you perform rudimentary edits on it, and it lets you label it and change its metadata content, rate your photos, print them, create albums, password protect your collections, auto-resizes photos for e-mails... all wrapped under an easy-to-navigate interface.



J River's Media Center software is highly recommended for its music, video and photo cataloguing features